

The Senate race is now nearly a coin flip

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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Recent polling in key states has tightened the race to control the Senate, giving Democrats a boost heading into the fall.

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Eurasia Group now sees the Senate race as a near-coin flip in which Republicans have a slight edge (55% odds, down from 60%) but are at risk of losing further ground if the macro-political environment turns more negative.

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We are closely watching several signposts, including President Donald Trump's approval rating, the generic congressional ballot, polling in state races, Republicans' financial advantage, and Democrats' ability to unify after divisive primaries.

The strategic picture in the Senate is unchanged. Democrats need 51 seats. That requires them to hold Georgia, Minnesota, New Hampshire, and Michigan, and flip four of North Carolina, Maine, Texas Ohio, Alaska, and Iowa. With North Carolina very likely to flip, the majority hinges on winning three of the remaining five while holding Michigan.

Recent polling points to a tightened race. In every Republican-held seat except Iowa, the bulk of recent polling has favored Democrats. With three months until election day, it is now worth taking this polling seriously as an indication of real Democratic strength. Democrats' sustained lead in Texas is their most bullish sign: Flipping Texas, Maine, and North Carolina would produce a split 50-50 Senate if Democrats hold on elsewhere. In current polling, Iowa is the "tipping point" state that would bring Democrats to 51 seats, but the ordering is likely to change as polling picks up in the coming weeks.

Two other factors also suggest Democratic momentum. Trump's approval rating has fallen to a second-term low in Silver Bulletin's tracker amid the resumption of hostilities with Iran. Democrats' lead in the generic congressional ballot has widened to 6.5 points and could increase further if their run of strong polling continues. Both trends weaken the Republican baseline in key states and reduce the degree to which Democratic candidates need to outperform partisan fundamentals.

Nonetheless, Republicans remain narrow favorites (55% odds, down from 60%, see United States: "Republicans remain the modest favorites in the Senate," 3 June 2026). Democrats' late-summer surge, in our view, is likely a high-water mark. Our view is based on the following factors:

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Underappreciated risks to Democrats in Maine and especially Michigan, as noted below;

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Reversion to partisan baseline: Both the 2018 and 2022 midterm cycles saw Democrats build early leads in Republican-held states, only for those leads to disappear as the fundamentals reasserted themselves in the later stage of the campaign;

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Recent signs of life for Republicans in Ohio and Alaska, where Democrats trailed in the most recent polls after leading for much of 2026, is a sign of potential reversion to come;

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A massive influx of cash coming to Republican candidates via various vehicles, including Elon Musk's and Trump's super PACs, which will have a big impact on get-out-the-vote efforts.

That said, this race clearly hangs in the balance, and a Democratic flip would not surprise us. A 50-50 split Senate, with Republicans retaining control thanks to the vice president's tiebreaking vote, is the most likely outcome.

Our outlook is in line with prediction markets but is more negative on Democrats than are most major election forecasters, who have coalesced around a view that Democrats are the 55% favorites.

Michigan is Democrats' biggest risk. In Michigan, Abdul El-Sayed has won a vicious primary fight against a moderate candidate and starts off down three points against Republican Mike Rogers. Nominating a dyed-in-the-wool progressive like El-Sayed has never been tried in a genuine swing state like Michigan, and he has an uphill battle in appealing to moderate suburban voters; his extremely narrow primary win also points to weaknesses among rural and Black voters, and will do little to resolve national Democrats' concerns about his electoral viability. Michigan's Democratic tilt this year should carry El-Sayed across the line, but this is a much closer race than Democrats would prefer.

We would consider altering our view if any of three signposts are hit: Democrats extend their lead in the generic congressional ballot to 8.5 points, a ten-point shift from 2024, which would move Iowa into toss-up territory; Trump's approval rating falls below 36%; or Democrats maintain their polling leads in individual races into mid-September. Other signposts include a Jasmine Crockett campaign for Democrat James Talarico in Texas, which would help Talarico consolidate Black support, and an early endorsement of El-Sayed by Michigan's Democratic establishment, which supported his opponent in the primary.

A 50-50 Senate would maintain Republican control. In a split Senate, the president's party controls the chamber, thanks to the vice president's tiebreaking vote. Senate Majority Leader John Thune (R-SD) would maintain his role, and committee chairs would remain Republican. Based on previous power-sharing arrangements in 2001 and 2021, committee membership would be split evenly, though reaching agreement in today's partisan environment may be more challenging. Coupled with likely Democratic control of the House, this even split would ensure legislative gridlock, with only the bare minimum of must-pass legislation—such as government funding and the debt ceiling—moving forward.

Nonetheless, Republicans would be able to fill executive or judicial vacancies.

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